



I



BEGINNINGS GENESIS

STUDY GUIDE • 1 OF 5

creation, the fall, Noah and Abraham

GENESIS 1-22

// START HERE

Welcome to Beginnings

Welcome to Beginnings. Over seven weeks we read key chapters of Genesis: creation, the Fall, the flood, Babel, the call of Abraham, God's covenant, and the testing of Abraham. These stories ask the biggest questions: who God is, who we are, what went wrong, and what God promises. We read for what the text says, ask honest questions, and leave each week with one step to try. You do not need to be an expert, only willing to read, listen and be kind with one another.

◆ 01 How a session works

90 MIN

The same rhythm every week, so the group can relax into it.

GATHER • 10 MIN

Follow up on last week's step. Did you do it?

READ • 10 MIN

Scripture read aloud, then notes.

DISCUSS • 35 MIN

Questions, not a lecture. Everyone speaks.

ACT • 15 MIN

One step, one outward habit, then prayer.

◆ 02 What you need

BRING

- ◆ A Bible in a translation you trust
- ◆ This guide and a pen
- ◆ Anything else

BETWEEN MEETINGS

- ◆ A few minutes a day with the passage
- ◆ One step to act on
- ◆ One person to tell

◆ 03 About the passages

This guide gives **references only** and does not print Bible text, so read from your own Bible. If you paste text into a page, use a public-domain translation such as the KJV or WEB. Old Testament references use Hebrew-Bible chapter and verse numbering; where an English Bible differs, the English reference is in parentheses. This guide has 7 sessions, in canon order, as part of a five-guide journey from Genesis to Revelation.

// THE FRAME

Our group

Small, steady and weekly. Fixing these early is what lets people open up.

SIZE

6-12

people. Small enough that everyone speaks.

RHYTHM

Weekly

same day, time and place.

SEASON

7

weeks with a steady membership, then regroup.

◆ 01 Details

DAY · TIME

Day, time

PLACE

Address or room

LEADER

Name

FACILITATOR
ROTATION

Who leads which weeks

SEASON

Start – end date

CHILDCARE /
FOOD

Plan

GROUP CHAT

Link or name

OPEN / CLOSED

Closed for the season

NEXT SEASON

When we regroup

◆ 02 Roster

#	NAME	CONTACT	PRAYER OR CARE NOTE
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

// AGREED TOGETHER

Our ground rules

Write them, read them aloud in week one, and sign. Edit freely: these are starting points, not commandments.

- 1 Show up and stay for the whole season.
- 2 What is shared here stays here.
- 3 Everyone speaks; no one dominates.
- 4 We may challenge one another kindly, and we agree to be challenged.
- 5 Let Scripture lead; opinions come second.
- 6 Pray for each other between meetings.
- 7 Your own rule

PHRASES FOR CHALLENGING KINDLY

- ◆ "Can you say more about that?"
- ◆ "What does the text say?"
- ◆ "What would it cost you to do that?"
- ◆ Your own phrase

WHEN A RULE IS BROKEN

How we will handle it: who speaks to whom, and how soon.

◆ We agree

Initials and date.

NAME

INITIALS

DATE

// CHOOSE HOW YOU READ

Four ways to study a passage

This guide assigns a method to each session. Change it if your group prefers another.

METHOD 1

Inductive

- ◆ Observe: what does it say?
- ◆ Interpret: what does it mean?
- ◆ Apply: what does it ask of me?

Best for: close reading

METHOD 2

Discovery Bible Study

- ◆ What does it say?
- ◆ What does it say about God? About people?
- ◆ What will I obey?
- ◆ Whom will I tell?

Best for: groups new to the Bible

METHOD 3

Lectio divina

- ◆ Read: a short passage, slowly
- ◆ Meditate: one phrase
- ◆ Pray: respond to God
- ◆ Rest: be still, then share

Best for: prayerful, quieter weeks

METHOD 4

Short accountability

- ◆ Did I do what I said?
- ◆ What did I read this week?
- ◆ Where did I struggle?
- ◆ Whom did I tell or serve?

Best for: pairs, or the opening of any session

◆ Methods in this guide

This guide uses Discovery, Inductive, Lectio divina. Short accountability opens every session in the “Gather” step.

// 7 WEEKS

Our season at a glance

The arc is set; adjust as you go.

WEEK	PASSAGE	THEME	METHOD	LEADS
1	Genesis 1–2	Creation: a good world	Inductive	Name
2	Genesis 3	The Fall	Discovery	Name
3	Genesis 6–9	Noah: judgment and mercy	Lectio divina	Name
4	Genesis 11:1–9	Babel: a name for ourselves	Inductive	Name
5	Genesis 12:1–9	The call of Abram	Discovery	Name
6	Genesis 15	God’s covenant with Abram	Inductive	Name
7	Genesis 22	The testing of Abraham	Lectio divina	Name

LAST WEEK OF THE SEASON

Celebrate, review what changed, and decide whether to continue, regroup or multiply. Each guide in this set continues the story in canon order, from Genesis to Revelation.

// SESSION 1 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

Creation: a good world

GENESIS 1-2 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Welcome everyone. Read the ground rules aloud (page 4) and share names.

WARM-UP

What is one good thing you noticed this week that you did not make?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 1-2 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 1-2

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** Which phrases repeat across the six days of chapter 1 (for example “God said” and “it was good”)? What do they show about how God works?

2 **INTERPRET** What do 1:26-28 and 2:7, 2:15, 2:18 say about humans: made in God’s image, given work, and made for one another? What does that suggest about God’s purpose for people?

3 **APPLY** God rests on the seventh day (2:1-3). What would it look like to treat rest as part of your week and not a reward?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Readers differ on how to take Genesis 1-2 (literal days, a literary framework, and other views). How can we hold our own view humbly and still listen to someone who sees it differently?

◆ 04 This week’s step

10 MIN

Choose one stretch of time this week, even an hour, to stop work, rest and notice what is good. Tell someone how it went.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Do one small act of care for creation or for someone overlooked: pick up litter at a park or check on a neighbor.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Psalm 8 slowly.

DAY 2

List three good things you did not make.

DAY 3

Ask God one question about rest or work.

DAY 4

Do this week’s step.

// SESSION 2 OF 7 · DISCOVERY

The Fall

GENESIS 3 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

When did you last hide or shift blame? Share a light example.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 3 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 3

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 OBSERVE What does the serpent ask and imply about God (3:1-5)? What happens right after the couple eat (3:6-8)?

2 INTERPRET Shame, hiding and blame follow (3:7-13). What does God's question "Where are you?" (3:9) and the clothing God makes (3:21) suggest about how God responds?

3 APPLY Where do you tend to hide or blame rather than tell the truth? What would honesty look like with God and one trusted person?

4 CHALLENGE KINDLY Traditions read 3:15 and the idea of "original sin" differently. What can everyone here affirm from the text about sin, and about God still caring for people?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Name one thing you will confess or put right this week. Whom will I tell? Share it with your accountability partner.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Write a note to someone who is isolated or carrying shame and let them know they are not alone.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Psalm 32.

DAY 2

Write what you tend to hide.

DAY 3

Ask God to show you where you are.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 3 OF 7 · LECTIO DIVINA

Noah: judgment and mercy

GENESIS 6-9 · LEADS: ·

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

When did you last wait a long time for something?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 6-9 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 6-9

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** How does Genesis describe the world before the flood (6:5-7, 6:11-12), and what does it say about Noah (6:8-9)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** What does it mean that God "remembered Noah" (8:1) and then promised never again to destroy the earth this way (8:21-22; 9:8-17)?

- 3 **APPLY** Noah built over a long time, trusting God (6:22). What might God be asking you to do patiently, without seeing results yet?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** People hold different views about the flood's scope and how to read it. How can we respect one another's views while we talk about what the story says about God's patience and mercy?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Pick one small, steady act of obedience for this week (same time each day) and tell your partner.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Offer practical help to a family in crisis, or give to disaster relief.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Genesis 8:1-19.

DAY 2

Write one thing you are waiting on.

DAY 3

Pray with the promise of 9:12-16 in mind.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 4 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

Babel: a name for ourselves

GENESIS 11:1–9 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What would you want to be remembered for?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 11:1–9 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 11:1–9

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What do the people of Babel want to build and why (11:3–4)? What does God do, and what is the result (11:5–9)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Why might wanting “a name” and safety from scattering be a problem here? What does the story show about human ambition and God’s purposes?

- 3 **APPLY** Where do you build for your own name or security (work, image, plans)? What would it look like to hold those plans with open hands?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Readers take Babel as judgment, as mercy, or as both. What do you see in the text that supports each view, and how can we hold the question kindly?

◆ 04 This week’s step

10 MIN

Notice one place this week where you are working to build your own name. Do one thing in secret that benefits someone else, and tell no one except your partner.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Serve in a way that gives someone else the credit: help behind the scenes at a community event.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Genesis 11:1–9 again.

DAY 2

Write where you want to be remembered.

DAY 3

Pray for humility.

DAY 4

Do this week’s step.

// SESSION 5 OF 7 · DISCOVERY

The call of Abram

GENESIS 12:1-9 · LEADS: NAME DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What is the farthest you have moved from home, and why?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 12:1-9 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 12:1-9

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does God tell Abram to leave, and what does God promise (12:1-3)? How does Abram respond (12:4-9)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** What does it mean that all the families of the earth will be blessed through Abram's family (12:3)? How does this answer the scattering of chapter 11?

- 3 **APPLY** What would it mean to trust God's promise over your own plans for security or reputation?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Abram was seventy-five and left without a map (12:4). What fears or good reasons might hold us back from stepping out, and how can the group help?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Identify one step of trust you have been putting off. Whom will I tell? Share it this week.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Be a blessing to someone from another place or background: invite a newcomer to share a meal.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Hebrews 11:8-10.

DAY 2

Write what you would have to leave behind.

DAY 3

Pray for someone far from home.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 6 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

God's covenant with Abram

GENESIS 15 · LEADS: NAME DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What promise has someone kept for you that mattered?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 15 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 15

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** What does Abram fear and ask (15:1–3), and what does God show and say in response (15:4–5)?

2 **INTERPRET** What does 15:6 say about Abram's belief and how God counted it? What does the strange ceremony (15:9–18) suggest about who carries the promise?

3 **APPLY** What promise of God do you find hard to trust? How might you bring that honestly to God, as Abram did?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Abram asks questions and God answers. Do we feel free to bring doubts to God and to each other? What helps or hinders?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Write down a promise from Scripture that speaks to your situation and read it daily. Tell your partner which promise you chose.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Encourage someone who is waiting on something (a job, a child, health) with a note or a visit.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Romans 4:1–5.

DAY 2

Look at the night sky; list reasons to trust God.

DAY 3

Pray honestly about one doubt.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 7 OF 7 · LECTIO DIVINA

The testing of Abraham

GENESIS 22 · LEADS: NAME DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What is the hardest thing you have been asked to give up?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Genesis 22 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

GENESIS 22

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does God ask, and how does Abraham respond and speak to Isaac (22:1–8)? What happens at the last moment (22:9–14)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** The story says God “tested” Abraham (22:1). What does it show about trust and about what God provides (22:8, 22:14)?

- 3 **APPLY** What do you hold most tightly? How could you hold it with open hands this week?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** This story troubles many readers. Which parts are hardest, and how do we stay with the text honestly without explaining it away?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Name one thing you hold tightly and pray over it daily. Tell your partner. Plan what you will do after the season ends.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Care for a child or a family in need through mentoring or by supporting a local children's charity.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Genesis 22 aloud.

DAY 2

Write what is hardest about this story.

DAY 3

Pray the words “The LORD will provide.”

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// PERSONAL REFLECTION

Five days, five short moments

The strongest measured predictor of spiritual growth is reading and reflecting on your own between meetings. Ten minutes is enough. Use the passage from your next session.

◆ 01 Read

10 MIN

Read the week's passage slowly, once. Note the reference.

◆ 02 Notice

10 MIN

Write one line: what stands out?

◆ 03 Ask

10 MIN

Write one question you would ask God about it.

◆ 04 Do

10 MIN

Take this week's step. What happened?

◆ 05 Pray

10 MIN

Pray for the person or place outside the group.

BRING TO NEXT SESSION

One thing you noticed, one question, one result from your step.

// TOGETHER AND BEYOND

Prayer requests

NAME	REQUEST	DATE	ANSWERED

◆ Beyond the group

An outward-facing habit keeps the group from turning inward: people and places we pray for or serve outside the circle.

WHO OR WHERE	PRAY / SERVE	WHEN	DONE

◆ Season project (optional)

One thing we do together for others.

Care for creation together: plan a neighborhood cleanup, a community garden day, or a project for a local park.

Project, date, who is leading · Your plan

// FOR THE LEADER

Leader's notes

The leader guides; the group discovers. Ask, listen, and resist teaching the whole passage.

BEFORE

- ◆ Read the passage twice and note your own questions
- ◆ Pick the method and rehearse the four questions
- ◆ Pray for each person by name

AFTER

- ◆ Text a note to anyone who was quiet
- ◆ Log the steps people named
- ◆ Your own follow-up

◆ 01 Timing guide

90 MIN

PART	MIN	NOTES
Gather & follow up	10	<u>Notes</u>
Open in prayer	3	<u>Notes</u>
Read	10	<u>Notes</u>
Discuss	35	<u>Notes</u>
This week's step	10	<u>Notes</u>
Beyond the group · prayer	12	<u>Notes</u>
Buffer	10	<u>Notes</u>

◆ 02 Hard moments in this guide

SCIENCE AND GENESIS

Traditions read Genesis 1–11 in different ways (literal, literary and others). Name that early, read for what the text says about God and people, and set the debate aside for another conversation.

HARD TEXTS

The Fall, the flood and Genesis 22 raise questions about evil and suffering. Acknowledge them honestly; you do not need a tidy answer in one evening.

PERSONAL PAIN

Sessions on shame, waiting and sacrifice can touch deep wounds. Offer to talk afterward and never press for disclosure.

◆ 03 Session notes

WHY THIS STRUCTURE

Groups reliably build belonging and forgiveness, but showing up does not by itself deepen Bible knowledge or growth. The design leans on discussion, written ground rules, a step to act on, personal reflection between meetings and an outward habit. The 6–12 size and 8–12 week season are practitioner advice, not a measured result.

// SESSION BY SESSION

What to watch for

A short note for each week. Edit freely.

WEEK	PASSAGE	WATCH FOR
1	Genesis 1–2	People may want to debate how the world began. Name that traditions differ, read what the text says about God and people first, and set the rest aside for another time.
2	Genesis 3	This passage is often read through a doctrinal lens. Keep the group on what the story says. Be gentle with anyone for whom shame is raw.
3	Genesis 6–9	Flood stories raise hard questions about suffering and judgment. Acknowledge them honestly; you do not need to settle them in one evening.
4	Genesis 11:1–9	Avoid turning Babel into a lecture on a particular group or on technology. Stay with what the text says about ambition and God's response.
5	Genesis 12:1–9	Not everyone is free to leave their circumstances. Frame “stepping out” broadly as trust, not only relocation.
6	Genesis 15	Do not rush to answer doubts with certainty. Let questions stand; Abram's did.
7	Genesis 22	This is one of the hardest stories in Genesis, and Jewish and Christian traditions read it in different ways. Expect strong reactions, never rush to a tidy answer, and if someone is distressed (for example by past abuse) pause and check in. Use this last session to review the season and plan what is next.